

Disarmament & International Security Committee

DISEC

Mandate

The Disarmament and International Security Committee or DISEC or the First Committee of the United Nations General Assembly handles issues related to international peace and security, disarmament and arms control, and regulation of armaments. It reviews threats to the international security and any measures that might be taken to limit the risk of armed conflict or enhance international security. DISEC deliberates on traditional security issues such as disarmament, conventional weaponry and nuclear disarmament as well as emerging security issues resulting from the scientific and technological advancements. The Committee can deliberate disarmament and international security-related issues and make recommendations to the General Assembly. The Committee also works on the wider UN disarmament system along with bodies like the United Nations Disarmament Commission and the Conference on Disarmament.

As per the UN charter, DISEC cannot act as an enforcement agency. DISEC cannot require states to give up weapons or conduct military operations, enforce criminal law, or compel states to accept a particular position on weapons. The Committee's role is purely diplomatic and deliberative where states deliberate, negotiate, work out language, draft resolutions and make recommendations on international measures for the General Assembly. DISEC resolutions are not in the same vein as security council resolutions which have more teeth as the security council has enforcement powers. The General Assembly resolutions on the other hand have a significant influence on international diplomatic and political affairs by setting international norms, reflecting the position of the international community, encouraging states to take on particular positions, and providing a diplomatic basis for further negotiations through other international frameworks.

In relation to the regulation of the Autonomous Weapon Systems, the Committee can review the implications on international security of weapons with varying levels of autonomy in targeting and engagement. The Committee can deliberate on developments in relation to the creation and use, transfer, proliferation, testing, accountability, and international regulation of autonomous weapons. They can

formulate considerations on whether international humanitarian law adequately covers autonomous weapons or encourages states to retain human involvement in the decision making concerning the use of force, encourage transparency and disclosure, recommend national level weapons review processes, encourage international cooperation on military artificial intelligence and provide a basis for further negotiations for an international agreement or rules concerning autonomous weapons. The Committee can also take into account the potential for the rapid development of autonomous weapons to contribute to an arms race, reduce barriers to the use of force, promote proliferation of such weapons, and challenges to international humanitarian law and to the accountability when an autonomous weapon kills unlawfully.

Therefore, for this particular agenda, the role of DISEC is not to take on the Seventh Review Conference of the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons. The CCW is a separate Treaty, which deals specifically with specific issues on certain conventional weapons. The DISEC can take up international security aspects of autonomous weapons and make recommendations to facilitate international negotiations pertaining to the CCW. Delegates should therefore focus their solutions to recommending international solutions, regulations, transparency measures, human involvement, weapons review processes, accountability, non proliferation, research standards, and other international norms rather than recommendations for the DISEC to impose a direct ban or punishment.

Section; 1) Introduction to the agenda

1.1 Key Terms and Definitions

Autonomous Weapon Systems (AWS): Weapons that can identify and engage targets with some level of autonomy after activation, without requiring a human to control every individual action.

Autonomous Weapon: A weapon capable of selecting and attacking targets based on information gathered by its sensors and programmed decision-making systems.

Artificial Intelligence (AI): Computer systems designed to perform tasks associated with human intelligence, such as analysing information, recognising objects, and making decisions.

Human Control: Human involvement in decisions concerning the selection and engagement of targets and the use of force.

Meaningful Human Control: The principle that humans should have sufficient knowledge, judgment, and control over a weapon to remain responsible for its use.

Lethal Autonomous Weapon Systems (LAWS): Autonomous weapons capable of using lethal force against targets with limited or no direct human control during the engagement.

Human-in-the-Loop: A system where a human must approve a weapon's decision before force is used.

Human-on-the-Loop: A system where a weapon can operate automatically while a human monitors it and can intervene when necessary.

Human-out-of-the-Loop: A system capable of selecting and engaging targets without human intervention during the engagement.

International Humanitarian Law (IHL): International law governing conduct during armed conflict and protecting civilians and others who are not participating in hostilities.

Distinction: The requirement under IHL to distinguish between civilians and combatants and between civilian objects and military targets.

Proportionality: The requirement that expected civilian harm must not be excessive compared with the anticipated military advantage.

Accountability: The principle that individuals and states must remain responsible for actions and consequences involving autonomous weapons.

Proliferation: The spread or transfer of weapons and military technology between states or to non-state actors.

CCW: The Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons, an international treaty framework that restricts or prohibits certain conventional weapons considered excessively harmful or indiscriminate.

Review Conference: A formal meeting where states review the implementation and development of a treaty and consider future measures.

Weapons Review: An assessment of a new weapon to determine whether its development or use complies with applicable international law.

1.2 Historical Background

1.2.1 Early Development of the Technology

The development of autonomous weapons did not begin with modern artificial intelligence. Decades of military practice have seen the use of weapons with automated or semi automated functionality, including guided missiles, automated defensive systems, mines, and weapons capable of responding automatically to threats. Earlier systems generally followed fixed, limited algorithms rather than making complex decisions. Advancing computing, radar, sensors, robotics, and communications technology gave rise to weapons capable of detecting objects, tracking targets, calculating vectors, and responding without continuous human input. These technological advances gave rise to the current discussion around autonomous weapons.

1.2.2 The Development of Modern Military AI

During the late twentieth century and early twenty first century, artificial intelligence and computing technology became crucial to modern military operations. Armed forces began to use computers for intelligence analysis, surveillance, observation, navigation, image recognition, logistics, and targetting assistance. The development of more sophisticated sensors enabled weapons and platforms to process huge quantities of information quickly. In turn, machine learning capabilities enabled systems to classify objects using large data sets. As computers and algorithms advanced, an opportunity arose for machines to undertake increasingly important roles in the targeting process with limited human input.

1.2.3 The Rise of Unmanned Systems

Unmanned aerial vehicles, or drones, played an important role in the evolution of modern autonomous technology. While earlier drones required extensive human input or remote control, later technology enabled many systems to navigate, surveil, and target autonomously. Drones became a critical link between manually controlled and autonomous systems. The distinction between remotely operated and autonomous technology became increasingly important. A remotely controlled drone still requires a human operator to make important decisions, while an autonomous system can undertake some roles on its own after initial activation.

1.2.4 The Humanitarian Debate Begins

As military technology became increasingly autonomous, humanitarian organisations became concerned with whether machines should be permitted to take on roles involving decisions over human life. The key discussion was not whether machines could take over these functions, but whether they could reliably distinguish between appropriate targets and civilians and whether humans could be held responsible for the consequences of their use. The International Committee of the Red Cross became an important interlocutor, stating that developments in autonomous warfare raised serious legal, ethical, and humanitarian issues. This perspective gave rise to a debate concerning the intersection of military technology, international law, and humanitarian principles.

1.2.5 The 2013 United Nations Report

In 2013, the UN Special Rapporteur on extrajudicial, summary or arbitrary executions, Christof Heyns, issued a report to the UN Human Rights Council concerning lethal autonomous robotics. The report discussed weapons systems capable of potentially selecting and engaging targeted objects without further

human input. Questions were raised concerning human responsibility, international humanitarian law, human rights, and the right to life. The report recommended that states consider a temporary international moratorium on the development, production, and use of lethal autonomous weapons until their implications could be carefully reviewed. While the report did not impose international law, it significantly raised awareness around the issue.

1.2.6 The 2014 CCW Expert Meeting

The Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons gave rise to an international forum for discussion around lethal autonomous weapons. A CCW Meeting of Experts was held in Geneva on 13-16 May 2014 to examine emerging technologies in the area of lethal autonomous weapons systems. Governments, international organisations, experts, and civil society representatives held discussions concerning technological developments, military applications, international humanitarian law, ethical questions, accountability, and possible regulation. The meeting was significant as it brought states together specifically for the purpose of examining whether autonomous weapons posed challenges requiring international responses.

1.2.7 The Importance of Critical Functions

One of the major debates in the international discussion concerned weapons carrying out critical functions such as searching for targets, detecting objects, identifying targets, tracking targets, selecting targets, and engaging targets. The ability to operate navigation functions autonomously is fundamentally different from the ability to carry out targeting functions. International debate began to focus more on the point at which autonomous technology began to make decisions which affected human life. This became the foundation of the discussion concerning meaningful human control.

1.2.8 Establishment of the Group of Governmental Experts

In 2016, states participating in the CCW agreed to establish a Group of Governmental Experts to examine emerging technologies in the area of lethal autonomous weapons systems. The Group of Governmental Experts, known as the GGE, became the primary diplomatic forum for discussion within the CCW. Meetings brought together state representatives and experts to discuss technological developments, military applications, legal obligations, ethical questions, accountability, human control, and regulation. The creation of the GGE marked a major turn from informal discussion to formal negotiations.

1.2.9 The First GGE Meeting in 2017

The first GGE meeting took place in Geneva in November 2017. States examined features and capabilities of autonomous weapons and considered the extent to which existing international humanitarian law applied to emerging technologies in the area of lethal autonomous weapons systems. The law was generally considered to apply to technology and weapons development even with the introduction of advanced autonomous technologies. Nevertheless, states failed to develop agreement over whether existing law was sufficient or whether additional international rules were necessary. This disagreement became a core point of the debate.

1.2.10 The 2018 Negotiations

The GGE continued its discussions of lethal autonomous weapons systems in 2018. States examined questions of human responsibility, human control, accountability, international humanitarian law, technological developments, weapons reviews, and possible regulation. Some states argued that autonomous weapons should be subject to new international restrictions or prohibitions, while others argued that

current law and procedures could meet these challenges. The discussions demonstrated that states generally recognise the importance of controlling the risks associated with autonomous weapons but disagree on the exact form of regulation.

1.2.11 The Eleven Guiding Principles of 2019

The CCW adopted eleven Guiding Principles concerning emerging technologies in the area of lethal autonomous weapons systems in 2019. These principles represented an important international consensus on the issue. They acknowledge international humanitarian law as fully applicable to weapons systems which may involve emerging autonomous technologies. They also stress human responsibility, accountability, weapons reviews, and international law, while noting the importance of considering developments in technology. Nevertheless, the principles do not provide a comprehensive legal treaty which regulates autonomous weapons. They instead provide a framework for political discussion.

1.2.12 The COVID 19 Period and Continuing Negotiations

The international debate continued over several years, despite difficulties caused by the COVID 19 pandemic. States continued to exchange proposals concerning autonomous weapons, human control, accountability, weapons reviews, and possible international regulations. The issue became more connected with the broader development of artificial intelligence and the rapid advancement of machine learning capabilities. Advances in computer vision, autonomous navigation, object recognition, and data processing made the debate more relevant to real world technology and not simply theoretical.

1.2.13 The Sixth CCW Review Conference

The Sixth Review Conference of the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons took place in Geneva in December 2021. The conference examined developments under the Convention and its various Protocols and considered the continuation of work on emerging technologies in the area of lethal autonomous weapons systems. The discussions reflected a continuing disagreement between states on the best international responses. Some advocates of new international rules sought to move towards treaties, while others stressed international humanitarian law, national weapons reviews, responsible military practices, and continued discussion within the GGE.

1.2.14 The Debate Over Prohibition

One of the most significant disagreements in the international debate concerns whether certain autonomous weapons should be entirely prohibited. Proponents of prohibition argue that weapons capable of independently making decisions to lethally engage should not be developed as they pose unacceptable humanitarian and legal risks and diminish accountability. Advocates for regulation argue that there are legitimate military advantages in the use of autonomous systems, particularly in defensive systems, speed, precision, and personnel protection. They argue that regulation should distinguish between different systems and uses rather than imposing a general prohibition.

1.2.15 The Debate Over Regulation

Some advocates of regulation argue that autonomous weapons should not simply be prohibited but should instead be regulated. Regulation can require human supervision, limit operating environments, restrict target types, require testing, set reliability standards, legal weapons reviews, accountability mechanisms, and technical safeguards. Under this approach, autonomous systems could potentially be used in certain circumstances when their operation is predictable and controlled. The debate over regulation therefore focuses on the identification of systems which

should be prohibited, those which could be regulated, and what level of human involvement should be required.

1.2.16 The Accountability Problem

Accountability became a major issue because an autonomous weapon cannot simply be viewed as a substitute for a human. If an autonomous system makes an unexpected decision and causes civilian casualties, questions arise about the responsibility of the commander who authorised its use, the operator who deployed it, the state which developed or used it, and potentially the designers and manufacturers involved in its creation. International discussions have stressed that increasing autonomy should not create an accountability vacuum in which responsibility is unclear simply because a machine is involved.

1.2.17 The International Humanitarian Law Debate

International humanitarian law became central to the AWS debate because weapons used in armed conflict must comply with international law. The principles of distinction, proportionality, and precautions in attack are of particular relevance. States must distinguish between civilians and combatants, avoid attacks which are expected to cause excessive civilian harm in relation to the expected military advantage, and take feasible precautions to reduce civilian casualties. The main question is whether autonomous systems can be operated within these requirements in the environments in which they are used. States generally agree that IHL applies to autonomous weapons but continue to debate whether existing law is sufficient to address the risks it poses.

1.2.18 Article 36 Weapons Reviews

Weapons reviews became a significant aspect of the international debate. Article 36 of Additional Protocol I to the Geneva Conventions requires states party to the Protocol to determine whether a new weapon, means, or method of warfare is prohibited by international law. For autonomous weapons, weapons reviews can examine characteristics, expected functionality, possible failures, operating environments, and compatibility with international humanitarian law. Advocates of stronger regulation argue that weapons reviews should be comprehensive and ongoing throughout the development of a system rather than a single procedure performed before a weapon enters service.

1.2.19 Increasing Real World Use of Autonomous Technologies

The debate has become more urgent as autonomous and AI enabled technologies increasingly appear in real world military environments. Modern conflicts have demonstrated the value of drones, automated surveillance, AI assisted intelligence, autonomous navigation, loitering munitions, and other systems which can perform aspects of the targeting process. Not every such system is a fully autonomous weapon, and the level of autonomy varies between systems, but their increasing use has demonstrated that autonomous military technologies are no longer theoretical and that international rules may need to address existing technologies.

1.2.20 The 2024 GGE Discussions

The GGE continued its work in 2024 through ongoing meetings in Geneva. States continued to discuss possible elements of an international instrument and other measures concerning emerging technologies in the area of lethal autonomous weapons systems. Questions of international humanitarian law, human responsibility, autonomy, accountability, weapons reviews, and regulation were discussed. The ongoing negotiations demonstrate that states are moving beyond acknowledging the problem to considering potential elements of future international regulations.

1.2.21 The Current International Divide

The international community continues to disagree over the future of autonomous weapons. There is a general recognition that international humanitarian law applies to weapons used in armed conflict and that human responsibility cannot simply disappear due to the autonomy of technology. However, states disagree over whether new international law is necessary, whether existing law can regulate these systems, whether certain weapons should be prohibited, and how human control should be defined. Some states and international organisations advocate a combination of prohibition and strict regulation, while others favour the development of responsible national policies and international principles.

1.2.22 Why the Seventh Review Conference Is Important

The Seventh CCW Review Conference is important because the international debate has evolved significantly since the first CCW discussions on autonomous weapons in 2014. Artificial intelligence has significantly advanced, military applications have expanded, and states have had more experience with autonomous technologies. The conference provides an opportunity for states to examine negotiations, developments, and existing international humanitarian law to determine whether additional measures are necessary. For DISEC, the historical development of this issue demonstrates why autonomous weapons have shifted from a future concern to a major issue involving international security, disarmament, humanitarian law, accountability, artificial intelligence, military strategy, and the future of warfare.

3. Root Causes

3.1 Rapid Development of Military AI and Technology

The rapid development of artificial intelligence, machine learning, robotics, advanced sensors, and computing has allowed weapons to perform increasingly complex tasks with reduced human involvement. AI can already assist with surveillance, image recognition, object classification, navigation, intelligence analysis, target tracking, and decision support. Advancements in sensors allow systems to collect information from larger areas and advanced computing allows that information to be processed extremely quickly. This creates the technological basis for weapons capable of performing several stages of the targeting process autonomously. The problem is intensified by the fact that technological development often precedes international law and diplomatic negotiations. A capability that may have been considered experimental a decade ago can become technically feasible much more quickly than states can negotiate a new international treaty governing it.

3.2 Strategic Competition Between States

Competition between states is a major driver of military AI development. States may believe that autonomous systems could provide strategic advantages through faster decision making, improved surveillance, reduced risks to soldiers, and the ability to operate in environments where human control is challenging. This creates a security dilemma because one country's development of advanced autonomous weapons can encourage other countries to develop similar systems to avoid falling behind. States may therefore be reluctant to accept strict restrictions if they believe potential rivals could continue developing the technology. Autonomous weapons are consequently linked to broader competition over AI, military technology, cybersecurity, drones, robotics, and advanced weapons. As nations compete for strategic advantage, the possibility of an arms race becomes a major factor in discussions surrounding international regulation.

3.3 Lack of Specific International Regulation

There is currently no single universally accepted international treaty that comprehensively regulates autonomous weapon systems. International humanitarian law already applies to warfare and consequently applies to the use of autonomous weapons, but countries disagree over whether existing rules are sufficient for the specific challenges created by autonomy. There is also no universally accepted definition of an autonomous weapon, no universally agreed definition of meaningful human control, and no universal agreement regarding which autonomous systems should be prohibited and which should be permitted under strict conditions. This creates legal and political uncertainty surrounding the development, testing, deployment, transfer, and use of autonomous weapons. The CCW Group of Governmental Experts has thus become an important forum for attempting to develop common international understandings and possible future measures.

3.4 Increasing Availability of Dual Use Technology

Many technologies used in autonomous weapons are not exclusively military technologies. Artificial intelligence, computer vision, satellite navigation, robotics, advanced processors, sensors, and machine learning are all widely used for civilian purposes. This creates a dual use problem because technology developed for civilian industries can potentially be adapted for military applications. AI systems used for autonomous vehicles, industrial robots, mapping, image recognition, and object detection can provide technological foundations which are relevant to military systems. Because these technologies are widely distributed throughout the global economy it is extremely challenging to prevent military access to every relevant component or algorithm. This makes traditional arms control methods more complicated and increases the importance of regulating how technologies are integrated into weapons rather than simply attempting to prohibit individual components.

3.5 Demand for Faster Military Decision Making

Modern warfare increasingly relies on speed. Missiles, drones, aircraft, cyber operations, and other systems can operate at speeds that may leave humans with very little time to analyse information and make decisions. Autonomous systems can process information much faster than humans and potentially detect and respond to threats within extremely short time periods. Militaries may therefore see autonomy as a way to maintain an advantage in environments where human reaction time becomes a limitation. However, increasing speed can also reduce the time available for human judgment and intervention. This presents a fundamental policy question: how can states benefit from rapid automated responses whilst ensuring that humans retain sufficient control over decisions involving lethal force?

3.6 Difficulty of Maintaining Human Control

As weapons become more autonomous, maintaining meaningful human control becomes more difficult. Human operators may supervise several systems simultaneously, operate from a distance, receive large quantities of information or have only seconds to respond to an autonomous system's decision. In a highly complex environment, operators may also become reliant on machine generated recommendations. This raises concerns about whether humans are genuinely deciding or simply approving decisions already produced by automated systems. The difficulty of defining and measuring meaningful human control is thus a major underlying cause of the international debate.

3.7 Unpredictability of Complex AI Systems

Advanced AI systems can produce results which are difficult to predict in every environment. Machine learning systems are trained using data and may perform differently when confronted with conditions that differ from their training environment. Battlefield conditions can rapidly change due to weather, civilians moving through combat zones, damaged infrastructure, electronic interference, camouflage, deception, and unexpected behaviour. A system that performs successfully during controlled testing may behave differently under real combat

conditions. This raises concerns about reliability, predictability, civilian protection, and compliance with international humanitarian law.

3.8 Increasing Proliferation of Unmanned and Autonomous Technology

The spread of relatively affordable drones and other unmanned technologies has made advanced military capabilities accessible to a wider range of actors. Autonomous or semi autonomous functions can potentially be integrated into systems that are smaller and cheaper than traditional military platforms. This creates concerns about proliferation because autonomous technologies may become accessible not only to major military powers but also to smaller states and potentially non state armed groups. The lower cost and increasing availability of commercial components can make controlling the spread of relevant technologies much more challenging than controlling traditional major weapons systems.

3.9 Accountability Gaps

Another root cause is the possibility of an accountability gap when a weapon makes decisions with limited human intervention. Traditional military operations normally involve identifiable decision makers who authorise, operate, or direct the use of force. With autonomous systems, responsibility may involve commanders, operators, programmers, manufacturers, military institutions, and states. If an autonomous system produces an unexpected result, determining who should be held responsible can be complicated. International discussions thus emphasise that increased autonomy must not result in a situation where responsibility is effectively transferred to the machine itself.

3.10 Rapid Militarisation of Artificial Intelligence

Artificial intelligence has increasingly become a strategic technology rather than merely a civilian research field. Governments are investing in national AI strategies, military research programmes, autonomous vehicles, surveillance systems, intelligence platforms and AI assisted defence capabilities. Major military powers are competing to integrate AI into command, control, intelligence, surveillance, reconnaissance, logistics, and weapons systems. As countries integrate AI throughout their armed forces, the barriers to developing increasingly autonomous weapons are likely to continue decreasing.

3.11 Absence of a Universal Definition

A major underlying problem is that states don't have a universally accepted definition of what exactly constitutes an autonomous weapon system. Different governments, researchers, international organisations, and civil society groups use different terminology and focus on different characteristics. Some definitions focus on whether a weapon can independently select and engage targets, whilst others focus on the degree of human supervision, the operating environment, the weapon's predictability, or the duration of autonomy. Without a common definition, states can disagree about which systems should be covered by international regulations. Establishing common terminology is therefore an important preliminary issue in creating effective international rules.

3.12 Difficulty of Applying Existing International Humanitarian Law

Existing international humanitarian law contains principles relevant to autonomous weapons including distinction, proportionality, precautions in attack, and military necessity. However, applying these principles to systems which can independently process information and select targets creates new practical questions. A human commander can theoretically assess a changing battlefield situation using judgment and contextual information, whilst an autonomous system may depend on sensors, software, predetermined parameters, and training data. Determining whether a particular autonomous system can reliably satisfy legal requirements under

particular circumstances is thus complex. This has created disagreement over whether existing law should simply be applied more effectively or supplemented by new international rules.

3.13 Economic and Military Incentives

The development of autonomous military technology is also driven by economic and strategic incentives. AI and robotics industries receive substantial investment from governments and private companies, whilst military procurement creates demand for advanced sensors, processors, software, drones and autonomous systems. States may view investment in military AI as part of maintaining competitive advantage and national security. Because autonomous technologies can potentially reduce manpower requirements and increase operational efficiency, governments may have incentives to continue developing them even whilst international negotiations regarding restrictions are unresolved. This creates tension between technological innovation, commercial interests, military requirements, and humanitarian regulation.

3.14 Difficulty of Verification and Enforcement

Even if states agree on international restrictions, verifying compliance with autonomous weapons regulations can be challenging. Software can be modified without changing the physical appearance of a weapon, and autonomy can depend on algorithms, datasets, communication systems, sensors, and operational parameters. Unlike some conventional weapons, determining the exact capabilities of an autonomous system may require access to sensitive military information and classified software. States may thus be reluctant to disclose details about their systems as doing so could reveal military capabilities. This presents a major challenge for any future international agreement that requires transparency, verification, or reporting.

3.15 The Risk of an Autonomous Arms Race

The combination of technological progress, strategic competition, military incentives, and limited international regulation provides the risk of an autonomous weapons arms race. If states believe that competitors are developing increasingly capable autonomous systems, they may accelerate their own programmes rather than wait for international negotiations. This could lead to greater investment in autonomous targeting, AI enabled drones, autonomous naval systems, robotic ground vehicles, and other military applications. An arms race can also make governments less willing to accept restrictions as they may fear that regulation will disadvantage them compared to states which continue developing the technology. This is one of the central security concerns behind international efforts to establish common rules prior to autonomous capabilities becoming more widespread.

4. Case Studies

4.1 Israel's AI Assisted Targeting and the Gaza Conflict

The use of artificial intelligence in the Israel Gaza conflict has become an important case study in discussions surrounding military AI and autonomous weapons. Reports have described Israeli military systems such as **“The Gospel”** and **“Lavender”**, which have been reported as using AI or algorithmic systems to process large amounts of intelligence and assist in identifying potential targets. Israeli officials have described AI as a tool for helping military personnel process information and identify targets, while investigative reporting has raised questions about the extent to which algorithmic systems influenced targeting decisions and the level of human involvement remaining in the process. The Israeli military has disputed some descriptions of these systems and has stated that its systems are intended to assist analysts and that human personnel remain responsible for approving strikes. The case is important for DISEC because it demonstrates the difficulty of distinguishing between AI assisted targeting and fully autonomous weapons. It also raises questions about human oversight, accountability, proportionality, civilian protection, the reliability of algorithmic recommendations, and whether existing international humanitarian law can adequately govern increasingly automated targeting processes. The case does not establish that Israel

used fully autonomous weapons, but it demonstrates why the international community is concerned about AI becoming increasingly integrated into decisions concerning the use of force.

4.2 Ukraine and Autonomous Drone Warfare

The war in Ukraine has demonstrated the rapid development of autonomous and semi autonomous military drone technology. Both Ukraine and Russia have extensively used unmanned aerial systems for surveillance, reconnaissance, targeting, and attacks. Some systems incorporate autonomous navigation, target recognition, electronic warfare capabilities, or other forms of automation, while many still require human operators for important decisions. Ukraine has publicly discussed the development of AI enabled drones and autonomous systems as a way to respond to battlefield conditions and reduce reliance on human operators. Russia has also invested in unmanned systems and AI related military technologies. The conflict is particularly important because electronic warfare can disrupt communication between drones and their human operators, creating incentives for systems to become capable of operating with greater independence. The widespread use of relatively inexpensive drones has also demonstrated how technological advances can lower the cost of sophisticated military capabilities. For DISEC, Ukraine provides a real world example of how autonomous and semi autonomous technologies can rapidly develop during an active conflict and why international rules concerning human control, targeting, accountability, proliferation, and weapons testing are becoming increasingly relevant.

4.3 The United States and Autonomous Defensive Weapons

The United States provides an important case study because it has developed and deployed military systems containing autonomous or automated functions while maintaining that appropriate human responsibility and legal review are necessary. One example is the **Phalanx Close-In Weapon System**, which can automatically detect, track, and engage certain incoming threats under particular operating modes. The system was developed to defend naval vessels against threats such as anti ship missiles and aircraft. Its existence demonstrates that autonomous functions are not necessarily limited to offensive weapons or systems designed to independently attack human beings. Autonomous and automated defensive systems can perform extremely rapid reactions that may be difficult for human operators to match. The United States has also established policies concerning

autonomy in weapons systems and requires legal reviews of weapons to ensure compliance with applicable international law. This case is important to the DISEC debate because it demonstrates why a universal approach that treats every autonomous function identically can be difficult. A defensive system designed to intercept an incoming missile presents different operational and humanitarian questions from a system capable of independently selecting human targets. It therefore supports the importance of defining exactly which autonomous functions should be restricted and what level of human control should be required.

5. Stakeholders

5.1 United Nations and UN General Assembly

The United Nations is a central stakeholder because autonomous weapons directly affect international peace, security, disarmament, and humanitarian protection. The General Assembly, particularly DISEC, provides a forum where all UN Member States can debate the risks of autonomous weapons and develop recommendations. The UN Office for Disarmament Affairs supports international disarmament processes, while other UN bodies examine the human rights and humanitarian implications of emerging military technologies. The UN's role is particularly important because any internationally accepted framework would require cooperation between states with very different military capabilities, technological capacities, and security interests.

5.2 Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons

The Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons is one of the most important stakeholders because it provides the primary international treaty framework under which governments have been discussing lethal autonomous weapons systems. Its Group of Governmental Experts brings states together to examine technological, legal, military, ethical, and humanitarian questions surrounding autonomous weapons. The CCW process is particularly relevant to the agenda because discussions concerning possible regulations, prohibitions, human control, accountability, and international standards have developed through this framework. The Seventh Review Conference is therefore directly connected to the future direction of international discussions on autonomous weapons.

5.3 Major Military Powers

Major military powers such as the United States, China, Russia, the United Kingdom, France, and other technologically advanced states are major stakeholders because they possess significant military research and development capabilities. These countries are developing or researching artificial intelligence, autonomous drones, robotics, surveillance systems, missile defence, and other advanced military technologies. Their positions are particularly important because they possess both the technological capability to develop autonomous systems and the strategic incentives to maintain military advantages. At the same time, their participation is necessary for any effective international framework because restrictions that exclude the largest military powers would have limited practical impact.

5.4 Developing and Non Nuclear States

Developing countries and states with smaller military capabilities are also important stakeholders because they may be affected by the proliferation of autonomous weapons without possessing the same technological or financial resources to develop comparable systems. Many developing states are concerned that rapid advances in military AI could increase technological inequality and create new security threats. They may also have interests in preventing an arms race and ensuring that emerging weapons technologies are regulated through inclusive international negotiations. Their participation is important because DISEC represents all UN Member States rather than only the major military powers.

5.5 International Committee of the Red Cross

The International Committee of the Red Cross is a major humanitarian stakeholder because of its role in promoting and protecting international humanitarian law. The ICRC has conducted extensive research and international consultations concerning autonomous weapons and has repeatedly highlighted concerns regarding human control, civilian protection, accountability, predictability, and compliance with international humanitarian law. It has argued for international rules concerning autonomous weapons, including prohibitions on certain systems and strict restrictions on others. Its expertise is particularly relevant to discussions about whether autonomous weapons can comply with the principles of distinction, proportionality, and precautions in attack.

5.6 Military and Technology Industries

Defence companies, artificial intelligence developers, robotics companies, semiconductor manufacturers, and other technology industries are directly involved in developing the technologies that can be incorporated into autonomous weapons. These industries develop drones, sensors, computer vision systems, navigation technologies, AI software, communications systems, and other components that can have both civilian and military applications. Their involvement creates an important policy challenge because technological innovation can provide significant military advantages while also creating humanitarian and security risks. International regulation must therefore consider how to encourage responsible innovation while preventing technologies from being used in ways that violate international law.

5.7 Civil Society and Human Rights Organisations

Civil society organisations, humanitarian groups, academics, weapons researchers, and human rights organisations have played a major role in raising public awareness about autonomous weapons. Organisations such as the Campaign to Stop Killer Robots have advocated for international restrictions and, in many cases, a legally binding prohibition on weapons capable of making life and death decisions without meaningful human control. These organisations contribute research, legal analysis, ethical arguments, and advocacy to international negotiations. Their involvement ensures that discussions are not limited to military and technological considerations but also include civilian protection, human rights, accountability, and ethical concerns surrounding the transfer of decisions over human life to machines.

6. QARMA

A resolution on **Regulating Autonomous Weapon Systems Ahead of the Seventh CCW Review Conference** must answer the following questions:

6.1 Definition and Scope

What exactly qualifies as an Autonomous Weapon System, and which weapons and autonomous functions will the proposed regulations apply to?

6.2 Human Control

What level of human control must be maintained over the development, deployment, targeting, and use of autonomous weapons?

6.3 Prohibited Weapons

Which autonomous weapons or functions should be completely prohibited because they cannot reliably comply with international humanitarian law?

6.4 Legal Compliance

How will states ensure that autonomous weapons comply with the principles of distinction, proportionality, military necessity, and precautions in attack?

6.5 Accountability

Who will be legally and politically responsible when an autonomous weapon causes unlawful harm: the state, commander, operator, developer, manufacturer, or another actor?

6.6 Weapons Testing

What international standards should be established for testing the reliability, predictability, accuracy, and safety of autonomous weapons before deployment?

6.7 Weapons Reviews

Should states be required to conduct comprehensive legal reviews of autonomous weapons before development, deployment, and significant modification?

6.8 Civilian Protection

What safeguards will prevent autonomous weapons from causing excessive civilian casualties, particularly in populated areas and complex battlefields?

6.9 Proliferation

How will the international community prevent autonomous weapons and their underlying technologies from being transferred to states or non state armed groups that may misuse them?

6.10 Arms Race

What measures can prevent an international arms race in military AI while allowing states to continue legitimate research and defensive technological development?

6.11 Transparency

Should states be required to report their development, testing, deployment, and stockpiling of autonomous weapons to an international mechanism?

6.12 Verification

How will compliance with any future international agreement be verified, particularly when autonomous weapons depend heavily on classified software, algorithms, and military data?

6.13 International Cooperation

How will developed states cooperate with developing states by providing technical expertise, training, and resources for responsible AI and weapons regulation?

6.14 CCW and UN Coordination

How will DISEC recommendations support and complement negotiations taking place through the **Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons** and its Group of Governmental Experts?

7. Bibliography

7.1 United Nations Charter, Article 1(1)

Establishes the UN's purpose of maintaining international peace and security and taking collective measures against threats to peace. It provides the broad foundation for international cooperation on autonomous weapons.

7.2 United Nations Charter, Article 2(1)

Establishes the sovereign equality of all UN Member States. This means that all states participating in negotiations on autonomous weapons are formally equal under the UN system.

7.3 United Nations Charter, Article 2(4)

Prohibits states from threatening or using force against the territorial integrity or political independence of another state, except where the UN Charter permits it. It provides the fundamental framework for international rules concerning the use of force.

7.4 United Nations Charter, Article 10

Allows the General Assembly to discuss matters within the scope of the UN Charter and make recommendations to Member States or the Security Council. This is important for DISEC because it establishes the recommendatory nature of the General Assembly.

7.5 United Nations Charter, Article 11

Allows the General Assembly to consider the general principles of cooperation in maintaining international peace and security, including **disarmament and the regulation of armaments**. This is one of the most directly relevant Charter provisions for regulating autonomous weapons.

7.6 United Nations Charter, Article 24

Gives the Security Council primary responsibility for maintaining international peace and security. It is relevant because the proliferation or use of autonomous weapons could potentially become a wider international security concern.

7.7 United Nations Charter, Article 25

Requires UN Member States to accept and carry out decisions of the Security Council. This demonstrates the difference between Security Council decisions and the generally recommendatory resolutions of DISEC and the General Assembly.

7.8 United Nations Charter, Article 26

Assigns the Security Council responsibility for formulating plans for regulating armaments and establishing a system for the regulation of armaments. It is directly connected to the wider UN framework for arms control and disarmament.

7.9 United Nations Charter, Article 39

Allows the Security Council to determine whether a situation constitutes a threat to the peace, breach of the peace, or act of aggression. It could become relevant if the use or proliferation of autonomous weapons creates a threat to international peace and security.

7.10 United Nations Charter, Article 41

Allows the Security Council to impose measures not involving armed force, including economic and diplomatic measures, when acting under Chapter VII. This demonstrates the enforcement powers available to the Security Council that DISEC does not possess.

7.11 United Nations Charter, Article 42

Allows the Security Council to take military action when measures under Article 41 are inadequate. It is mainly relevant for understanding the difference between the Security Council's enforcement authority and DISEC's recommendatory mandate.

7.12 General Assembly Resolution 78/241, “Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems”

Adopted in 2023, this was the first General Assembly resolution specifically dedicated to lethal autonomous weapons systems. It recognised the rapid development of emerging technologies, including artificial intelligence and autonomy, and called for continued international consideration of their humanitarian, legal, security, technological, and ethical implications.

7.13 General Assembly Resolution 79/62, “Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems”

Adopted in 2024, this resolution continued the General Assembly's examination of lethal autonomous weapons systems. It continued the process of collecting views from Member States and examining the implications of autonomous weapons for international peace, security, humanitarian law, and human rights.

7.14 Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons, Article 1

Defines the scope of the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons and establishes its application to particular conventional weapons. The CCW is the

principal treaty framework within which states have conducted negotiations concerning lethal autonomous weapons systems.

7.15 Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons, Article 8

Provides procedures concerning amendments, review, and further development of the Convention and its Protocols. It provides the legal basis for the Review Conference process.

7.16 Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons, Article 8(3)

Provides for Review Conferences to examine the operation and implementation of the Convention and its Protocols. It is particularly relevant to the Seventh CCW Review Conference mentioned in this agenda.

7.17 CCW Guiding Principles on Emerging Technologies in the Area of Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems, 2019

The eleven Guiding Principles adopted in 2019 represent an important area of international consensus. They affirm that international humanitarian law applies to autonomous weapons, that human responsibility must remain within the chain of command, and that responsibility cannot simply be transferred to machines. They also recognise the importance of weapons reviews and continued international discussion.

7.18 CCW Group of Governmental Experts on Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems

The Group of Governmental Experts is the main diplomatic forum within the CCW for discussing lethal autonomous weapons systems. It examines human control, accountability, international humanitarian law, weapons reviews, technological developments, and possible future international regulation.

7.19 Additional Protocol I to the Geneva Conventions, Article 36

Requires states party to Additional Protocol I to determine whether a new weapon, means, or method of warfare would be prohibited under international law. This is directly relevant to autonomous weapons because legal weapons reviews can assess whether new autonomous systems comply with international obligations.

7.20 Additional Protocol I, Article 48

Establishes the fundamental principle of distinction. Parties to an armed conflict must distinguish between civilians and combatants and between civilian objects and military objectives. This is one of the most important provisions when considering autonomous targeting systems.

7.21 Additional Protocol I, Article 51

Provides protection to civilians against dangers arising from military operations and prohibits attacks directed against civilians and indiscriminate attacks. It is highly relevant to concerns about autonomous systems incorrectly identifying or engaging civilians.

7.22 Additional Protocol I, Article 57

Establishes precautions in attack. Parties must take feasible measures to verify targets and minimise civilian harm. This is important when determining whether autonomous weapons can operate safely and lawfully in complex environments.

7.23 Geneva Convention IV, Article 27

Provides protections for civilians during armed conflict and requires respect for their fundamental rights. It supports the wider humanitarian principle that technological developments in warfare must not remove protections owed to civilians.

7.24 Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court, Article 8

Defines war crimes within the jurisdiction of the International Criminal Court. It is relevant to autonomous weapons because the use of technology does not eliminate responsibility for unlawful acts committed during armed conflict.

7.25 Security Council Resolution 1540 (2004)

Requires states to prevent non-state actors from acquiring nuclear, chemical, and biological weapons and their means of delivery. Although it does not specifically concern autonomous weapons, it provides a useful model for international non-proliferation, national legislation, export controls, and cooperation against dangerous military technologies reaching non-state actors.

7.26 Security Council Resolution 2370 (2017)

Addresses the prevention of terrorists from acquiring weapons and related materials. It is relevant to autonomous weapons because future international regulations may need to address the possibility of autonomous and AI-enabled weapons being acquired or developed by terrorist organisations and other non-state armed groups.

7.27 Security Council Resolution 2663 (2022)

Continues the work of the Security Council's 1540 Committee concerning non-proliferation and international cooperation. While its primary focus is weapons of mass destruction, its mechanisms for national implementation, reporting, assistance, and international cooperation can provide models for preventing dangerous technologies from spreading.

7.28 UN Special Rapporteur Report on Lethal Autonomous Robotics, 2013

The 2013 report by UN Special Rapporteur Christof Heyns examined the humanitarian, legal, ethical, and accountability issues created by weapons capable of operating without direct human intervention. It helped bring autonomous weapons into wider UN discussions and raised the question of whether humans should retain meaningful control over decisions involving lethal force.

7.29 ICRC Report on Autonomous Weapon Systems, 2016

The International Committee of the Red Cross examined the humanitarian, legal, ethical, and military concerns surrounding autonomous weapons. It emphasised the importance of human control, predictability, accountability, and compliance with international humanitarian law.

7.30 UN Secretary-General, “Our Common Agenda” and Artificial Intelligence Discussions

The UN Secretary-General has increasingly addressed the international implications of artificial intelligence, including the need for international cooperation, responsible development, human rights protection, and international governance of emerging technologies. These discussions are relevant because military AI and autonomous

weapons form part of the broader global challenge of governing rapidly developing artificial intelligence.

7.31 Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons, Protocol I

Protocol I prohibits weapons designed or intended to injure through fragments that cannot be located in the human body by X-rays. While it does not regulate autonomous weapons, it demonstrates how the CCW can establish specific restrictions on particular weapon technologies based on humanitarian concerns.

7.32 Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons, Protocol III

Protocol III restricts the use of incendiary weapons against civilians and in certain circumstances against military objectives. It provides an example of the CCW approach of imposing specific restrictions on weapons based on their effects and humanitarian consequences.

7.33 Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons, Protocol IV

Protocol IV prohibits the use and transfer of blinding laser weapons. It is particularly useful as a historical example of the international community establishing restrictions on a developing military technology before its widespread use created greater humanitarian consequences.

7.34 Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons, Protocol V

Protocol V concerns explosive remnants of war and establishes obligations relating to reducing the dangers created by unexploded and abandoned explosive ordnance after conflicts. It demonstrates how international agreements can address the long-term humanitarian consequences of weapons.

7.35 Universal Declaration of Human Rights, Article 3

Article 3 states that everyone has the right to life, liberty, and security of person. Although the Declaration does not specifically regulate weapons, the protection of human life provides an important human rights foundation for discussions about autonomous systems capable of using lethal force.

7.36 International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights, Article 6

Article 6 recognises the inherent right to life and states that no one shall be arbitrarily deprived of life. It is relevant to autonomous weapons because the development and use of systems capable of independently using lethal force raises questions about protecting the right to life during armed conflict and other situations covered by international law.

7.37 Main Legal Principles for the Resolution

The most important legal principles for this agenda are **distinction, proportionality, precautions in attack, accountability, human responsibility, weapons reviews, non-proliferation, and the regulation of armaments**. A strong DISEC resolution should connect its proposed measures to these existing principles rather than treating autonomous weapons as a completely separate area of international law. The resolution should also recognise the existing work of the CCW and the GGE while proposing practical measures concerning human control, testing, transparency, accountability, proliferation, and international cooperation.